to Tirunelveli the same afternoon; he had made his point that he was not one to yield to threats.[60]

On 12 March, when the security proceedings continued, VOC and his associates decided to offer the security demanded of them. But now Wynch refused to accept it and remanded them to custody by locking them in Palayamkottai Central Jail immediately.

The next day, Tirunelveli and Tuticorin erupted in violence. The mood was already charged, and in the days leading up to this event, 'Europeans … were boycotted and openly insulted.'[61] An eerie silence descended on the Tirunelveli marketplace, with shops being shut. Soon a crowd gathered, and amid shouts of 'Vande Mataram' and 'V.O. Chidambaram Pillai' marched on the main road where all the government offices were situated. As the infamous Sedition (Rowlatt) Committee's report described it '[e]very public building in Tinnevelly town …' was attacked. 'It was marked by wholesale and deliberate destruction of Government property in open defiance of constituted authority.'[62] The King-Emperor's portrait was pulled down, and when policemen charged the crowd, the insurgents urged them to join the protest. The crowds confronted an armed Collector Wynch, who uncocked and fired his revolver. In the police firing that followed, four men were killed. Tuticorin too erupted in violence. In open defiance of prohibition orders, a huge public meeting was conducted in Mosquepettai or Vandipettai. When Sub-Collector Ashe charged the crowd with a posse of policemen, the angry crowd counter-attacked rather than disperse. Interestingly, the port officer Lieutenant W.L. Kelly joined hands with Ashe in the charge. Many policemen were injured and fled the scene.

Hundreds of arrests were made following these protests described officially as the 'Tinnevelly Riots' and many were sentenced to long terms of imprisonment. The government held the Swadeshi leaders, especially the propaganda of VOC and Siva, responsible for the violence. In an act of collective retribution, a huge punitive police force was stationed in Tirunelveli and Tuticorin for six months, the expenses covered by a 'punitive' tax imposed on the entire populace.[63] VOC and Siva's arrest was